

Postdoctoral Award [Cohort 3]

Overview

Opportunity status: Open

Type: Career development

Opening date: 23 April 2026 at 1:00 pm

Closing date: 16 June 2026 at 1:00 pm

Reference ID: 2026/427

Ready to apply?

Apply now

(https://awardsmanagement.nihr.ac.uk/s_Login.jsp?dest=/Apps/app_viewopportunity.jsp%3Fappid%3D105112%26nextlevel%3D1%26opportunityid%3D10243797)

The NIHR Postdoctoral Award is aimed at anyone with a PhD or a submitted PhD thesis under assessment who has not yet been appointed to a professorial post. This award provides funding to help you develop your research career across a broad range of postdoctoral career stages.

The award will support you to undertake research in any scientific discipline or sector. You'll need to demonstrate a contribution to improving health and care within the NIHR's remit.

The Postdoctoral Award also supports individuals who wish to develop their academic careers while continuing as practitioners, including health and care professionals and PhD holders in local authority settings.

Watch webinar: Get tips for putting together a strong application

(<https://youtu.be/ZJliANSXaNI>)

Who can apply?

To be eligible for the award, you must:

- hold a relevant PhD or MD, or have submitted your thesis for examination at the time of application. You must have been awarded your PhD or MD by the time you attend the interview
- if you hold a Professional Doctorate, you must contact us before you start your application and we will help to confirm your eligibility.
- propose to undertake the award at a Higher Education Institution (HEI), NHS body, Local Authority or other provider of health or social care services, either in England or a participating devolved nation
- not already hold a chair position at the point of application
- for clinical applicants, you must have completed relevant pre-registration training

Please see more details about eligibility on the [Postdoctoral Award page](#).

Devolved nation applications

Scotland, Northern Ireland and Wales are not participating in Cohort 3.

What is available through a Postdoctoral Award?

The award provides funding for:

- your salary, including clinical service or practice time, where applicable
- a research project, including
 - a support post to assist your research, plus £3,000 towards their training and development
 - shared staff costs
- the cost of a tailored academic and professional development programme
- annual conference budget

How much can you apply for?

Except for staff and conference costs, there are no strict budgetary caps. All costs must offer value for money and be fully justified in your application. Full details of costs for this scheme are available on the [Postdoctoral Award page \(/node/31536\)](#). Guidance about how to cost your application is available via the NIHR finance guidance.

Award duration and part-time options

This is a flexible award, and you are able to choose a duration of between 2 and 5 years Full Time Equivalent (FTE). You can also take it up on a full-time or part-time basis between 50% and 100% FTE. [Calculate](https://www.nihr.ac.uk/personal-career-development-award-durations) (<https://www.nihr.ac.uk/personal-career-development-award-durations>) your award duration.

If you work in a clinical or local authority setting, you will have the option to request up to 40% of your time to be dedicated to clinical practice and development work, with this time

funded by the award.

Key dates

23 April 2026

Application opening date

16 June 2026

Application closing date

June - December 2026

Application assessments

January - March 2027

Interviews and application funding decision

April - September 2027

Award start dates

Strategic priorities and highlight notice

We are particularly interested in receiving career development award applications that will develop skills and experience within the [Oral and Dental Hygiene highlight notice \(/research-funding/themed-funding-opportunities/oral-dental-health-highlight-notice\)](#) as well as our strategic priorities:

- social care
- mental health
- public health
- health data science
- researchers working in a local authority setting
- applicants hosted by post-92 HEIs and non-university hospital practice settings

Applications received under these strategic priorities and the oral and dental hygiene highlight notice will still have to meet the same quality threshold required for funding, but will be given priority if the number of fundable applications exceeds the maximum that can be funded.

Partnership awards

These awards are jointly funded opportunities with our charity and industry partners. The partnership opportunities for this submission window are:

Breakthrough T1D

[Breakthrough T1D](https://breakthrought1d.org.uk/) (<https://breakthrought1d.org.uk/>) (formerly JDRF) is the leading global type 1 diabetes (T1D) research and advocacy charity. They help make everyday life with T1D better while driving towards cures. They fund research to cure, treat and prevent type 1 diabetes, and welcome applications that align with our global research strategy and address our priority areas: early detection, disease modifying therapies, cell therapies and improving lives. They want to work together to fulfil our vision of a world without type 1 diabetes.

Sarah Berry, Research Partnerships Manager

researchcommunications@breakthrough1d.org.uk

[\(mailto:researchcommunications@breakthrough1d.org.uk\)](mailto:researchcommunications@breakthrough1d.org.uk)

[\(mailto:researchcommunications@breakthrough1d.org.uk\)](mailto:researchcommunications@breakthrough1d.org.uk)

020 3410 6055

Kidney Research UK

[Kidney Research UK](http://www.kidneyresearchuk.org) (<http://www.kidneyresearchuk.org>) is interested in funding research that's focused on the immediate priorities in its research strategy: Transforming Treatments, Multiple Health Conditions and Health Inequalities.

Elaine Davies, Director of research operations

elainedavies@kidneyresearchuk.org

01733 367835

Moorfields Eye Charity

Moorfields Eye Charity is interested in funding research in eye health, vision research, ophthalmic-related service improvement, education or clinical practice. Please note: applicants will normally be hosted by either the Moorfields Eye Hospital NHS Foundation Trust or its main HEI partner (University College London). If hosted by another institution a direct collaboration with and benefit to Moorfields Eye Hospital NHS Foundation Trust must be demonstrated in order to be eligible to apply for a Partnership Fellowship.

Martin Cordiner, Funding Manager: martin.cordiner@nhs.net

Pfizer

You can apply for a partnership award with Pfizer and propose research in areas:

- atopic dermatitis
 - alopecia areata
 - Vitiligo
 - Inflammatory Bowel Disease (IBD)
 - Idiopathic Inflammatory Myopathies (IIMs)
-

Rosetrees Trust

Rosetrees Trust's overall aim is to fund translational research in any clinical area that has a clear plan and trajectory to deliver patient benefit within the short to medium term. They are very keen to build relationships with our grant holders with a view to providing longer-term funding to exceptional candidates.

Dr Vineeth Rajkumar, Head of Research

VRajkumar@rosetreescio.net

0208 951 2588

The Colt Foundation

[The Colt Foundation](http://www.coltfoundation.org.uk) (<http://www.coltfoundation.org.uk>) funds high quality research in environmental and occupational health with a particular interest in projects that are likely to inform policy and working practices and thereby improve the health and wellbeing of workers and the wider population. In recent years the Foundation has also focused on building research capacity within work and health by supporting academics with fellowships of up to five years. Examples of recently funded project grants include: understanding and tackling the barriers to employment experienced by autistic adults; Long Covid in NHS staff: demographic and psychosocial risk factors and the relationship with sickness absence; Investigating the differential toxicology of

micro-, nano-plastic particulate co-exposure with various ambient air pollutants upon healthy and diseased lung models in vitro; and A mixed-methods study to evaluate the influence of bio-psycho-social and cultural factors on the presence of work-exacerbated asthma. Many more examples of projects funded by the Colt Foundation can be found on their website.

Tash Heydon, Director

tash@coltfoundation.org.uk

01798 342 831

The Defence Medical Services (DMS)

The DMS provides primary care and specialist medical services to over 130,000 people in the UK Armed Forces. NIHR is partnering with the Defence Medical Services (DMS) to co-fund research career development opportunities for healthcare professionals which they can undertake whilst serving in the military and continuing to serve in their current roles.

If you work for Defence Medical Services and you are interested in a PoDA-Defence Medical Services Partnership award, please contact Philip Woodgate to discuss before beginning an application. We cannot accept any applications for this partnership award that have not been pre-approved by DMS.

[Learn more about this partnership \(/news/nihr-military-partnership-provide-research-opportunities\)](/news/nihr-military-partnership-provide-research-opportunities)

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Contact Details: philip.woodgate100@mod.gov.uk

Stroke Association

The [Stroke Association](https://www.stroke.org.uk/about-us/research) (<https://www.stroke.org.uk/about-us/research>) wishes to fund research which clearly addresses priorities for stroke within the top ten topics from the James Lind Alliance (JLA) 2021 Priority Setting Partnership (PSP) for either prevention and acute care, or rehabilitation and long-term care.

Melanie Steele

Research Policy and Partnerships Manager

Melanie.Steele@stroke.org.uk (<mailto:Melanie.Steele@stroke.org.uk>)

Apply now

(https://awardsmanagement.nihr.ac.uk/s_Login.jsp?dest=/Apps/app_viewopportunity.jsp%3Fappid%3D105112%26nextlevel%3D1%26opportunityid%3D10243797)

Application guidance

Please read our award-specific applicant guidance to help you complete all aspects of your application. You must read the application guidance alongside the linked resources, which detail specific requirements for this award.

- [Postdoctoral Award page](/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award) (/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award)
- [Postdoctoral Award applicant guidance](/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award/how-to-apply/application-guidance) (/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award/how-to-apply/application-guidance)
- [Postdoctoral Award assessment criteria](/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award/assessment-criteria) (/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award/assessment-criteria)
- [finance guidance for applicants](/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants) (/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants)
- blog: [characteristics of a great Postdoctoral Award application](/blog/characteristics-great-postdoctoral-award-application) (/blog/characteristics-great-postdoctoral-award-application)

If you use generative AI when writing your application, you must clearly cite and acknowledge it.

Application form uploads

You must provide the following uploads as part of your application:

- narrative CV
- letters of support from your contracting organisation and your partner organisation, if applicable
- detailed research plan
- Gantt chart or project plan document
- references
- career development programme
- schedule of Events Cost Attribution Tool (SoECAT), if applicable

Choosing a contracting organisation

You must choose a contracting organisation to include in your application. Your proposed contracting organisation must be based in England and:

- a recognised HEI
- an NHS body
- a local authority
- any other third sector or publicly funded provider of health and/or social care services, such as a hospice or commissioned social enterprise

You must be based in England at your contracting organisation for the duration of the award, except for travel for research, training, or development activities as outlined within

the proposal.

You must also choose a partner organisation if:

- your employer for the duration of the award will not be your contracting organisation.
- you are requesting salaried clinical or practice time through the award, but you will not undertake it within your contracting organisation

We will not support applications in which the individual is living overseas from their contracting organisation. Read more about choosing your contracting and partner.

Application process

Find out how to apply for this funding opportunity and what you need to do to get your application ready. Please read all the information and guidance carefully before submitting your application.

How to apply

When you're ready to apply, log into our new awards management system. You'll need to create a new account to submit your application.

The closing date for this application is **16 June 2026 at 1pm**. Late submissions will not be considered.

Please note that you will not be able to submit your application until all parties, such as your Head(s) of Department and mentors, have confirmed their participation on the system. Be sure to allow enough time for these confirmations before the deadline.

If you're applying to multiple career development opportunities and one application is successful, you'll need to decide which opportunity you want to continue with.

Our commitment to inclusion

We are committed to [creating a diverse and inclusive culture](/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion) (/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion). We encourage applications from people from all backgrounds and communities bringing diverse skills and experiences.

Additional support

We are committed to removing barriers to inclusion wherever possible. We want to maximise the inclusion of disabled people and individuals with long term health conditions. We want to make sure our processes are as inclusive as possible and this might mean we need to make adjustments to the application process or for the undertaking of the award if successful.

If you need to discuss a reasonable adjustment to support completion of the application, please contact personal.awards@nihr.ac.uk (mailto:personal.awards@nihr.ac.uk)

You should not disclose detailed information of reasonable adjustments required to undertake the award in your application. Costings for reasonable adjustment that you, or any co-applicants may require, however should be included within your budget. See our [finance guidance](/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants) (/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants) for more information. We will discuss this with you further if your application is successful.

Additional resources

Explore additional resources to support your application.

Research Support Services

The [NIHR Research Support Service \(RSS\)](https://www.nihr.ac.uk/explore-nihr/support/research-support-service/) (https://www.nihr.ac.uk/explore-nihr/support/research-support-service/) provides free and confidential advice to those

developing applications for NIHR funding.

Assistance is primarily focused on refining research questions, research design and methodological support. The RSS also assists prospective applicants in developing public involvement and engagement strategies. This includes involvement of service users, carers and practitioners in social care.

The RSS is delivered collaboratively through eight hubs, which each support a broad range of research designs, from pre-application through to post-award delivery, as well as providing specialist topic or methods expertise.

RSS specialists centres

- [RSS Specialist Centre for Social Care](https://www.nihr.ac.uk/explore-nihr/support/research-support-service/social-care-specialist-centre.htm) (https://www.nihr.ac.uk/explore-nihr/support/research-support-service/social-care-specialist-centre.htm)
- [RSS Specialist Centre for Public Health](https://www.nihr.ac.uk/explore-nihr/support/research-support-service/public-health-specialist-centre.htm) (https://www.nihr.ac.uk/explore-nihr/support/research-support-service/public-health-specialist-centre.htm)

Local authority settings

If you are based in a local authority setting, you may consider seeking input from elected members within the local authorities, as they represent their communities' interests.

NIHR Applied Research Collaborations (ARCs)

Our ARCs support applied health and care research tailored to local population and system needs. These 15 local partnerships between NHS providers, universities, charities, local authorities, Academic Health Science Networks, and other organisations also focus on implementation research to enhance the uptake of research findings into practice.

You should consider contacting their local ARC prior to applying to explore potential support. Find full information, [including how to find your local ARC](https://www.nihr.ac.uk/about-us/what-we-do/infrastructure/applied-research-collaborations) (<https://www.nihr.ac.uk/about-us/what-we-do/infrastructure/applied-research-collaborations>).

NIHR Schools

NIHR Schools exist to develop evidence-based practice that will inform and improve practice within particular fields and welcome contact from individuals seeking support and to connect with others who share their interests. Full information is available via the school webpages:

- [NIHR School for Social Care Research](https://www.sscr.nihr.ac.uk/) (<https://www.sscr.nihr.ac.uk/>)
 - [NIHR School for Public Health Research](https://sphr.nihr.ac.uk/) (<https://sphr.nihr.ac.uk/>)
 - [NIHR School for Primary Care Research](https://www.spcr.nihr.ac.uk/) (<https://www.spcr.nihr.ac.uk/>)
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James Lind Alliance (JLA)

JLA is an NIHR-funded non-profit making initiative, bringing patients, carers, and healthcare professionals together in Priority Setting Partnerships (PSPs) and is a useful resource to prospective applicants for postdoctoral applicants.

PSPs prioritise unanswered questions or evidence uncertainties, forming a ‘Top 10’ list of research questions that matter most to those who rely on the research. Over 160 Top 10s have been agreed, and all priority research questions are [published on the JLA website](http://www.jla.nihr.ac.uk/) (<http://www.jla.nihr.ac.uk/>).

Local authority researchers

Developing Local Authority Researchers is a new workspace on the [FutureNHS platform](#)

(<https://future.nhs.uk/system/login?nextURL=%2Fconnect%2Eti%2FLocalAuthorityHealthCareResearch>) which supports researchers based within local authorities and allied settings to network, share knowledge and receive notifications of future development opportunities. The workspace is open to all, and includes an active forum, monthly virtual catch-up meetings, a members directory, and links to other resources and opportunities.

Contact details

- for help with your application contact: personal.awards+poda@nihr.ac.uk
(<mailto:personal.awards+poda@nihr.ac.uk>)
- for more information, visit the [postdoctoral award page](#)